THE HIDDEN COST

Interactive vs Video: The Numbers Nobody Talks About

Cheap production ≠ low total cost

AppletPod

01

70-80% completion waste

Video production: $10K. Learners who finish: 20-30%. Your actual cost per completer: $33K-$50K. That $7K-$8K you didn't spend on interactive? You wasted it on unwatched video.

Most video budgets pay for content nobody finishes.

02

90% retention decay in one week

Of the 30% who finish video, 90% forget it within a week. Your effective reach: 3% of enrolled learners. Interactive practice systems with feedback loops: 45% retention. That's 15X better.

Completion dashboards hide the retention gap.

03

The iteration tax

Video needs full re-shoots for updates. Over 3 years: 80 days of production time. Interactive systems built on frameworks: update variables, not entire modules. Over 3 years: 42 days total.

Initial speed doesn't matter if updates take months.

04

Cost per behavior change (the real metric)

Video: $10K ÷ 2.5 effective learners = $4K per person. Interactive: $50K ÷ 45 effective learners = $1.1K per person. When you measure what actually changes behavior, interactive is 4X cheaper.

Production cost is the wrong denominator.

05

The production efficiency trap

Video feels faster because initial delivery is quick. But measured over 3 years (including updates, re-shoots, retention loss), interactive becomes more efficient. You're optimizing for the wrong timeline.

Fast to ship ≠ fast to maintain.

The completion gap

58% Video completion (LinkedIn Learning 2026)

90% Interactive completion (same study)

32pt Gap stakeholders ignore when choosing video

What to measure instead

Total cost of ownership (production + waste + updates over 3 years)

Cost per learner who demonstrates mastery (not just completion)

⚡ Time to iterate when business requirements change

Stop measuring production cost. Start measuring behavior change.

I build interactive systems in 3-4 weeks.

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